prostitute Englishwomen, and replace them with women from eastern Europe. In the 1930s, by one estimate, there were over 50,000 prostitutes in Calcutta alone. Only with the nationalist movement and international campaigns in the 1940s did endorsement and encouragement of military prostitution decline, though much earlier, an early Indian feminist movement had already abhorred the practice.

Independent India passed an anti-trafficking law, the Immoral Traffic Prevention Act in 1956, but it did not curtail trafficking. The law has been criticized for victimizing the victim rather than the trafficker and customer. In 2016, the National Crime Records Bureau recorded nearly 20,000 people who were trafficked that year alone—half of whom were children and the other half women.[39] These were only the reported cases and conceal the real magnitude of flows. West Bengal was party to one-third of those cases, followed by Rajasthan and Maharashtra. Mumbai's red light area, Kamathipura, had an old connection with the Kamathi workers from the region in present-day Telangana in south India, which continues to be a source of trafficking. One study in the Rayalaseema region of Andhra Pradesh, the same region where centuries before Afghani immigrants had controlled the traffic in horses, found trafficking to be high among the erstwhile Banjara-Lambada groups.[40] The stories of the survivors or return migrants revealed the role of poverty in sex trafficking, the deception involved and regret. Not all trafficking is for sex work as it can also include domestic helps, work in dangerous settings and even marriage, within India and outside. Neither is all of it entirely by coercion. Yet it places a large number of women and children in highly vulnerable positions.

Trafficking represents one end of the spectrum of female migration in India. At the other end, women have also moved by their own volition for work and become successful. Cornelia Sorabji, a pioneer lawyer, was the first woman to study law at Oxford in the late 19th century. She moved to different places in her life championing the cause of women. Of her, it was said:[41]